



Introduction

Suryavarman II

Angkor Wat is 'the' temple of Suryavarman II who reigned from 1113 to about 1150 AD. Little is, unfortunately, known of this king, and that which can be known has been gleaned from the inscriptions of Preah Vihear, Phnom Rung, Phnom Sandak and Ban That.¹ What can be established is that Suryavarman II, although probably a vassal prince from the Mun valley (in present-day northeastern Thailand) and certainly a maternal grandson of a sister of Jayavarman VI (r.1080-1107), was not in direct line of succession to the Khmer throne. His great uncle Dharanindravarman (r.1107-1113) had legitimately inherited the throne from his elder brother Jayavarman VI. According to inscriptions, young Suryavarman challenged the aged Dharanindravarman in a battle which "lasted only for one day" and that he "jumped on the enemy king's elephant and killed him, stripping the defenceless royalty from Dharanindravarman". The Ban That inscription confirms that he fought the battle when still "in his early youth, at the end of his studies".

Suryavarman's usurpation of the throne marks the consolidation of the Mahidharapura dynasty, which was to prove one of the most brilliant in Khmer history, providing such great kings as Suryavarman himself and Jayavarman VII (r. 1181-c.1215). Suryavarman was very much a warrior king and launched repeated expeditions against Dai Viet (Vietnam) and Champa (in the centre of present-day Vietnam). With the Chams he is also known to have formed alliances against the Dai Viêt. Most of these campaigns ended in defeat, although his expansion to the West met with better success, and Khmer forces managed to occupy Thai territory, and in particular the town of Lavo (Lopburi, present-day Thailand). Suryavarman seems to have died during a

maritime expedition against the Champa and Dai Viêt between 1148 and 1150.

One of the greatest mysteries of Suryavarman II's reign is why Angkor Wat, the largest Khmer temple built up to that time, and one of the largest in the world, is dedicated to Vishnu. Although the Pancharatra sect of Vaishnavism had enjoyed a certain degree of popularity in Cambodia since early times, we know from inscriptions that Shaivism remained the dominant form of Hinduism within the kingdom. On the whole, the Khmer kings had been largely Shaivite in their beliefs. It is even possible that Suryavarman II was himself primarily a devotee of Shiva. Given the absence of any historical records treating this subject, one can only speculate whether Suryavarman II's departure from the strict Shaivism of his Angkorean predecessors was part of an increased syncretism, allowing the contemporaneous veneration of two sectarian beliefs, or whether it in fact reflected a personal preference of Suryavarman II for the Pancharatra sect. There had been an illustrious precedent in King Suryavarman I (r.1002-1050) who, although a Shaivite, permitted, and possibly encouraged, Buddhism. One could hypothesise that the new king through his own name may have believed himself to be connected with Surya, the old Vedic god of the solar dynasty who had been gradually replaced by a far more powerful god of the same dynasty, Vishnu. Or it may be that as a usurper, Suryavarman II identified himself with Krishna who in the original texts was seen rightfully to usurp the worship of Indra. Thus Angkor Wat's relief depicting the story of Krishna fighting the Indra cult (S.12), and instructing the cowherds to abandon the old ritual and to worship him, could symbolise Suryavarman's replacement of the older cult of Shiva with a new spirit of Vaishnavism. Other possible reasons for this switch

of royal cults may be that Suryavarman was looking for a deity more 'helpful' as a protector against the internal and external strife that attended his accession to the throne. After all, a god like Vishnu had incarnated in order to redeem man, and he also promised a final release from the endless cycle of reincarnations.

Besides building Angkor Wat, Suryavarman II also completed the construction of the Shaivite Var Phu temple that had been initiated during the last year of the reign of Jayavarman VI, and many images were erected in it by royal ordinance between 1118 and 1139. Suryavarman made no attempt to remove the celebrated Bhadresvara *linga* of Shiva of this temple from its position as the national divinity of the Khmer nation. He also restored the Shaivite temple of Ishvarapura (Banteay Srei), and completed the Phimai complex in northeastern Thailand, which was dedicated to both Shiva and Vishnu. All of this would seem to indicate that the devotion and patronage of Suryavarman II was syncretic towards the two great Hindu sects.

Angkor Wat

Although there is no evidence identifying the architects of the temple, it is likely that Divakarapandita, the brahmin in Suryavarman's service, contributed to its conception and planning. Divakarapandita was from a long line of illustrious brahmins, and he must have been quite old by Suryavarman's accession, having served the previous two kings Jayavarman VI and Dharanindravarman I.² The building of the temple commenced upon Suryavarman taking the throne and continued for approximately the next thirty years.

A variety of Indian myths and legends from Hindu texts are skilfully illustrated at Angkor Wat in the reliefs of the 3rd enclosure: in the two western corner pavilions and along the galleries where they are displayed in extraordinarily long panels. Called here Large Panels, they have a height that remains constantly in the region of 240 centimetres; the length of each of the eight reliefs varies from 48 to almost 94 metres. It is important to mention here that out of the eight Large Panels, only six were sculpted in the XII century. Indeed, the relief of the

Churning of the Ocean of Milk was abandoned before completion, despite being so important for symbolising the concept of creation essential to the Pancharatra cult. The wall surfaces of the northeastern quadrant were not sculpted until the XVI century, as their inscriptions indicate.³ Nevertheless, they were possibly done on the basis of drawings stencilled in ink in the XII century on the walls of the galleries (Roveda, 1991).

Each of the western corner pavilions is sculpted with 12 exquisite panels which are of fundamental significance within the symbolic framework of the temple. Furthermore, they are almost surely contemporaneous to the enclosure's Large Panels (excluding the ones of the northeastern quadrant) since they are sculpted in the same style, they all are completed, and no inscriptions prove the contrary. In contrast, the two eastern corner pavilions of the same enclosure were left bare of reliefs; again, emphasis is on the western part of the temple in accordance with being dedicated to the lord of the West, Vishnu.

Vaishnavism in XII century Angkor

From at least the early centuries of the Christian era, the Khmers were familiar with Hinduism as well as Buddhism. By Angkorean times, Hindu religious belief was focused on the concept of the Trinity of Brahma, Vishnu and Shiva who fulfilled the three cosmic functions of creation, conservation and dissolution. Hinduism was also concerned with the monistic tendency of both Shaivism and Vaishnavism, which emphasised the transcendence and immance of one god. In Vaishnavism, greater importance was laid on the devotional aspect, or *bhakti* – the trusting abandonment of the self to the god, which alone is the source of salvation.

By the end of the X century the worship of Vishnu was divided between three different schools: Pancharatra, Bhagavata and Satvata. By far the most popular of these was the Pancharatra,⁴ a doctrine requiring the worship of Vasudeva (Vishnu) as the highest (para-Vasudeva) central source from whom four forms (*vyuha*) successively emanate. The first to be manifested from him is Vishnu-Vasudeva, followed by his brother Samkarshana (Balarama), his

son Pradyumna and his grandson Aniruddha. This takes place in a sequence where each emanation originates from the anterior one "like a flame proceeding from another flame". In other terms, the *vyuha* are distinct manifestations of the undifferentiated central reality of para-Vasudeva, and each has its own characteristics called *guna* (glorious attributes). In addition to the *vyuha*, the Pancharatra texts outline the other manifestations, somehow at a lower level, in which para-Vasudeva 'descends' (incarnate) in this mundane world. These are detailed in a variety of *avatars*, the best known of which are the *deshavatars*, or ten incarnations of Vishnu. These manifestations are understood as a hierarchical cosmic diagram (mandala) with para-Vasudeva at the centre of ever-expanding permutations of his power, like ripples in a pond (Atherton Packert 1985: 211).⁵

In Cambodia, the earliest mention of the sect is in the inscription of Prince Gunavarman of Funan (V century), followed by the Stele of Baset (VII century) which mentions the five daily rites required of the faithful. The inscriptions of Kuk Sla Ket (XI century; K.522) and of Thvar Kdei (K.165), both contain the concepts of the Four Emanations. By the IX and X centuries, the Pancharatra had become a significant force in Khmer society and underwent some divergence from the Indian orthodoxy. In the inscriptions of Pre Rup (961 AD) and Prasat Kok Po (X-XI century) the Khmers interpreted Vishnu's emanations as having the qualities of Nature (*gunas*), while standard Pancharatra doctrine considered them 'supernatural'.⁶ Khmer Pancharatra, however, still retained its quietism, a passive devotional contemplation, with withdrawal from all things of the senses.⁷

With regards to the visual representation of Pancharatra concepts at Angkor Wat, it has to be noted that although reliefs narrating stories of Vishnu's *avatars* are very common, there are no images of Vishnu, Samkarshana, Aniruddha and Pradyumna as *vyuha*. There are, though, illustrations of earthly events of Aniruddha as the prisoner of Bana (pediment of the southern gallery of the 3rd enclosure), and of Pradyumna in the battle of Krishna against Bana to free Aniruddha (in the Large Panel LP. 6). However, Pradyumna and Aniruddha are perceived as *avatara* and not as *vyuha*;

they derive from Puranic myths and not from the early Pancharatra texts.

One of the basic themes of the Pancharatra doctrine, that of the creation-dissolution cycle, has a prevalent position at Angkor Wat's main entrance. Over the central door of the Western *Gopura*, one can see a lintel (Plate 16) elaborately sculpted with Vishnu immersed in sleep on the snake Ananta who himself rests in the Ocean of Eternity. Vishnu is ready to activate his power at each new period, starting thus a new cycle of creation. This myth is reproduced also in the Cruciform Pavilion and in the northwestern corner pavilion. Since the myth of the Churning of the Ocean of Milk is considered here to be associated with the Pancharatra's concept of creation, it is not surprising to find it depicted in several reliefs throughout the temple (LP. 4, S. 1 and on various doorjambs).

The concept of the *avatara* is also essential to the Pancharatra. The prefix *ava* means 'down' and the Sanskrit verb 'tri' translates into 'cross over'; *avatara*, therefore, means the coming down of the deity. Western dictionaries' translation is that of 'incarnation', a more materialistic, carnal term than one that would explain the transfer of an infinitesimal part of Vishnu (a hair in the above myth) from high in the sky down to earth into the form of one of his *avatars*. It is interesting to note that, amongst the Hindu pantheon, the *avatara* doctrine refers essentially to Vishnu. Shiva takes the human form only once, that of an enchanting mendicant in the episode of the Pine Forest (see relief S. 4 in the southwestern corner pavilion). In modern belief, an *avatara* has the function of allowing the divinity to become the object of the devotee's worship and meditation. It is to Vishnu alone that the *avatara*'s doctrine refers and he appears in ten different manifestations: as a fish (Matsya), a tortoise (Kurma), a boar (Varaha), a man-lion (Narasimha), a dwarf (Vamana), and in manly semblance as Parashurama (Rama with an axe), Rama, Krishna, Buddha (disputed) and Kalki (the *avatara* still to come).

The texts illustrated

The entire temple is richly decorated with splendid reliefs, mainly of the narrative type⁸ which are visual

retellings of episodes from the two Sanskrit Epics the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana*, and the *Puranas*, and as such, they can be considered a narrative genre in their own right. The proliferation of narrative reliefs in Cambodia since Angkorean times suggests that they had become a popular device for communicating religious beliefs and historic events through the medium of 'stone writing'. Although images in reliefs endure in time and space, they or their content have to be reactivated each time by the viewer for narrative completion.

Khmer narrative reliefs are not accompanied by a text giving the name of the story or of the personage depicted, or written clues that allow the identification of the text, as in mural paintings and sculptural reliefs from India and other parts of Southeast Asia. The short inscriptions exceptionally found on the Large Panels of the Historic Procession and of the Heavens and Hells at Angkor Wat (LP. 2 and LP. 3) only give the names of the main personages and the names of the punishments without revealing to what text or circumstances the reliefs refer.

Nevertheless, Angkor Wat's narrative reliefs clearly refer to popular events from the Epics and the *Puranas*, visually narrated in a way which is generally faithful to the original Sanskrit texts in terms of the plot – even down to the last detail. The reliefs reproduce and continue the emotional values of the original texts without altering them, and in strict obedience to the orthodoxy imposed by the brahmins and elite. The constant concern of the Khmers to adhere closely to the Indian texts applies also to other reliefs of the Angkorean period (IX through XIII centuries) from different locations and centuries, implying that their creators must have relied either on written texts or on a faithfully maintained oral tradition. One is tempted to assume that, as in India, *Ramayana* manuscripts written on palm leaf could have been common amongst the elite.⁹ Another reason for such faithfulness to the original texts could be that the sculptors adhered fanatically to a set of *shilpashastras* (sculpting manuals). In particular, such manuals would have offered only a limited choice of subject matter, and thus excluded the possibility of any idiosyncratic choices. Unfortunately, for the moment, there is no answer to all these assumptions, since no written text predating the XVII century has been found in Southeast Asia.

Remaining faithful to the original texts may not have been easily achieved, considering the possible existence of different 'tellings' of the *Ramayana*, various Puranic versions of the same story, and popular local folkloric legends. The complexity of this relationship is further increased by the inevitable problems inherent in any translation of literary texts into visual images, between the meaning of words and the meaning of images. When looking at the reliefs under consideration, we face the process of production and exchange of meanings. The Khmers have encoded the messages (the reliefs) with particular meanings on the basis of the significance that Indian texts had within the culture of their time. It seems that if the *Puranas*, *Harivamsa* and *Mahabharata* were addressing general metaphysical, religious and political principles, the *Ramayana* emphasised personal values in the figure of the protagonist, Rama the hero, who could be easily identified with the figure of the king, explaining thus his great popularity. *Mahabharata* stories are known at Angkor Wat primarily from a Large Panel of the 3rd Enclosure (LP. 1), where the only event chosen is that of the greatest conflict of Indian mythology, the battle of Kurukshetra. It may be that the Khmers could not see in the *Mahabharata* the heroic figure of the god/king they needed, since even Arjuna – the most popular personage – was considered too dependent on Krishna for choosing the path of action.

The Ramayana

This story of Rama is the most widely diffused tale in South and Southeast Asia. The date of Valmiki's compilation of the Sanskrit poem of the *Ramayana* remains obscure.¹⁰ Its core may not date to later than the middle of the VI century BC,¹¹ while the first and last books are probably later additions. The collation of a definitive version took place between the II century BC and the III century AD.

The basic story, like those in many different Asian oral and literary traditions, has branched out in a variety of plot developments, with different beginnings and endings. It has various forms of narrative, numerous incidents, different kinds of characters, and remarkable details woven into an intricately interconnected series of events. Several of these events may have been introduced according to the taste and fancy of a long lineage of narrators around



central or subsidiary ideas, heroes or villains. In northern India, the story of Rama is mentioned in the *Mahabharata* (about 800 BC), and the Tamil version contains verses referring to Valmiki's epic. This posits the existence of Rama's story well before its literary versions. It is likely that these, or similar oral traditions, circulated in Southeast Asia with the arrival of Indian traders.

The Thai and Cambodian written versions of the story of Rama, respectively the *Ramakien* and the *Ramaker* (The Glory of Rama) are XVII to XIX century compilations of previous tellings, and are too late to have been used for the reliefs of Angkor Wat. They diverge from other Asian versions insofar as they do not emphasise Rama's heroism, or his victory, but instead the 'glory' of his spiritual order. It has to be noticed that both the *Ramakien* and the *Ramaker* are composite names revealing a Sanskrit linguistic construction (Rama-glory or *Ramakirti*), the reverse of the normal Thai or Khmer construction. Therefore, these texts may refer to the title of an old Indian work, now lost, or a local sanskritised name of an Indian version, not of local origin. The term *Ramaker* is often replaced by *Ramkier*, *Reamker* or by the Sanskrit *Ramakerti* (Bizot 1989: 28).

In the Cambodia of the Angkorean period, it seems that the *Ramayana* in use pertained to Valmiki's tradition. The stele of Veal Kantel of the VII century¹² mentions that the *Ramayana* (and therefore possibly Valmiki's version, and not a local version such as the *Ramaker*) had to be recited daily, without interruptions, as were the *Harivamsa* and the *Puranas*. Exceptionally, however, there is at Angkor Wat a divergence from Indian texts with regard to the iconography and details of a few scenes. This problem was stressed by some scholars who advanced the theory of the existence of an 'elusive' version of the *Ramayana* not only in Cambodia but also in other countries of Southeast Asia.¹³

Scholars started to speculate that probably this 'elusive' local version might be reflected in the text of the *Ramaker*, arguing that there are some elements foreign to the *Ramayana* which are common in the *Ramaker*. Many singularities apparent in the *Ramaker*, however, lose their uniqueness when compared with the texts of the rich Puranic literature or the *Mahabharata*, or even with other sectarian Bengali, Tamil, Jaina and most of all, Malay legends of Rama.¹⁴

At this point, one can assume that the Khmers must have been familiar with an oral and/or written version of the *Ramayana* that was very close to Valmiki's telling but that excluded the first and seventh books of the Valmiki version. Some local colour had also been added in such details as the presence of a monkey in the scene of the Churning, the strange moving target with a bird which Rama has to hit at Sita's *svayamvara*, the belief that Rama and his friends returned to Ayodhya by boat and not on the Pushpaka chariot (Phimai, Thailand), and the sea animals which attempt to destroy the causeway to Lanka (Phimai; see Boeles 1969: 163). Furthermore, there are some iconographic anomalies in the representations of the *rakshasas* Viradha and Kabandha. Some of these variations of the 'elusive' Khmer version were incorporated into the *Ramaker* and *Ramakien* in their written form of the XVI and XVII century. Could it be called 'Proto-Ramaker'?

The Puranas

The *Puranas* are Sanskrit verse texts of a non-Vedic origin containing mythological accounts of the events in the lives of Hindu gods. They were all composed between 500 and 1500 AD, but are based on much earlier material. Of the two categories – the *Mahapurana* (or 'great', 'major') and the *Upapurana* ('minor') – the former includes the texts illustrated in Khmer reliefs, the most popular being the *Bhagavata Purana* (made around 950), the *Shiva Purana* (730-1350), the *Vishnu Purana* (made around 450) and the *Brahma Purana* (900-1300). The *Puranas* stress *bhakti* and miraculous manifestations of divine grace, and remain the dominant texts of Hinduism's religiosity. They also reflect the theoretical cosmogony of the two epics, the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana*, expanding and systematising their chronology. They are the more exact and better worked-out versions of the subcontinent's mythology and historical traditions. Most *Puranas* have a strong sectarian bias, so that the same myths appear in very different versions in different *Puranas*.

The *Bhagavata Purana* is the Puranic text that has exercised the most direct and powerful influence on the opinions and feelings of the Indian and Khmer people. Dedicated to Vishnu, or Bhagavata, it consists of 18,000 verses grouped in 332 chapters and

divided into 12 books (*skandha*). Its tenth book, narrating in detail the stories of Krishna's life, has been the most frequently consulted for the study of the reliefs of Angkor Wat; its stories are also the most popular in Indian folklore.

The Mahabharata and the Harivamsa

The *Mahabharata* comprises 100,000 verses divided into 18 books, supplemented by a nineteenth, the *Harivamsa* which deals more with events concerning Krishna's life. Like the *Ramayana* and the *Puranas*, it grew into its present form over a long period of time, from about 400 BC to 400 AD.

The epic narrates the events before, during and after the great battle for kingship fought at Kurukshetra between the Pandavas and the Kauravas, two families descended from the great hero king, Bharata. Central to the *Mahabharata* is the decline of *dharma*, the cosmic law and order, at the onset of the Kali Yuga age of history (the present era). To the sixth book of the *Mahabharata* belongs the *Bhagavad Gita*, the fundamental Hindu text. In it the emphasis is on Krishna's (an ally of the Pandavas) transformation of the battle of Kurukshetra from a mythic one between *devas* (Pandavas) and *asuras* (Kauravas) into a cosmic event during which Krishna re-establishes the *dharma*. The battle is also referred to as the *dharmakshetra* (field of *dharma*) because during it, the *dharma* met its ultimate test. At the most critical moment of the fight, Krishna – as advisor of the Pandava prince Arjuna – transcends the action and evokes a comparable transcendence in those who attend him, making his discourse to Arjuna, the *Gita*, itself the locus of *bhakti*.

The *Harivamsa*, probably composed around 400 AD, is generally considered as an appendix of the *Mahabharata*, although some scholars believe it is a Puranic compilation, probably of southern Indian origin. Of its three parts, the first is introductory and gives details of the creation and of the patriarchal and regal dynasties; the second contains the life and adventures of Krishna; the third deals with the future worlds and the corruption of the Kali age. The second part is the most relevant here, since it has inspired the reliefs at Angkor Wat depicting events in the life of the god.

The life of Krishna can be divided into three main parts, of which the third contains the events in

the *Mahabharata*. The first part of his life, his infancy through his adolescence, concerns several miraculous deeds that gradually reveal his divinity. However, during this first period, Krishna is also involved in fights against the demons sent to kill him by his evil cousin Kamsa. These events are amply illustrated both at Angkor Wat, and in many other Khmer temples. As Krishna's adult life was chronicled in the *Mahabharata*, the *Harivamsa* was needed to relate the story of his birth and childhood. The *Harivamsa* subtly captures Krishna's dual character as epic hero and religious teacher; it is both a tale of adventures and a way to express religious truths.

The second stage of his life starts with the slaying of Kamsa, which brought him into conflict with Jarasandha and his supporters and many others whose atrocities were afflicting the world. As an adult, Krishna has to face hard social and political realities, and his slaying of Jarasandha is a very significant event in his life because with it he liquidates his political enemies. During this period, he is also involved in epic events such as his abduction of the beautiful Rukmini, the imbroglio of the recovery of Satrajit's jewel, the combat with Indra for the possession of the Parijata tree, the fight against the *asura* Bana to rescue his son Pradyumna, and the uprooting of Mount Maniparvata. These episodes, as well as violent battle scenes, are common in late Indian iconography.

The function of the reliefs

The reasons for the creation and execution of the reliefs have been debated at length by numerous Western scholars. What was the scope for their existence? This analysis is important because the function of the reliefs may determine their meaning. Were the stories narrated in the reliefs addressed only to a select few? Were they instead meant to educate and illuminate the pilgrims or visitors to the temple – ordinary people, or were they meant to be simply part of the sculptural decoration of the temple, having purely an aesthetic appeal? Was the decoration of temples with reliefs an element of the mechanism of merit-gaining on the part of the king? One aspect of the problem was approached by George Coedès¹⁵ in his theory of the magic function

of the reliefs. Thus, in Khmer monuments the role of the decorations (statues and reliefs with scenes and personages) was not aesthetic, because the Khmers did not have the concept of 'art for art's sake'. For them the reliefs had an 'evocative' function, that of bringing life to the temple. Coedès believed that the images of the gods had a 'magic' power that would transform the temple into a real divine world. The representation of *apsaras* and *devatas*, celestial dancers and courtesans, all over the walls of the temples would transform a terrestrial stony residence into a heavenly palace. At Angkor Wat, the celestial palaces as seen in the relief of the Heavens and Hells (LP. 3), are in the shape of pavilions flying in the sky supported by garuda and lions. At the royal terraces of Angkor Thom, robust caryatids/atlas have the task of transforming symbolically the monument into a flying palace.¹⁶

It follows that this celestial transformation is enacted also by reliefs representing legendary events of gods and mythological heroes, which would give life to the temple with their real presence. In this sense the reliefs were not made to edify visitors, but to contribute to the materialisation on earth of the divine world. The reliefs of Angkor Wat narrating the stories of Suryavarman II, and the ones of Bayon dealing with Jayavarman VII, had the objective of animating the temples with the actual presence of these kings. This is why – Coedès believed – it is essential for the images to be exact, correct in every detail, otherwise they would fail the objective, like a magic ceremony in which the essential rite was omitted or wrongly performed. This resulted in the simplification and, at the same time, complication of the iconography's task. If the sculptors knew the specific texts or were following a particular tradition, they could control all the details of the image and the iconographic interpretation would be simple. If not, the identification of the scenes would be doubtful or incomplete, if not impossible. It was essential to make clear which text the reliefs referred to, or by which version the sculptor was inspired, otherwise the scenes could not be totally explained and so could not be claimed to fulfil their function.

In the same publication, Coedès expressed his other theory that Angkor Wat had a funerary function. This was based on the discovery of some sort of sarcophagi in various Khmer temples, Coedès being

unconcerned that these 'sarcophagi' may not have been contemporaneous with the construction of the temple, or that they may have been moved by tomb robbers. For him, in general, royal temples were funerary buildings, private rather than public temples. Palace-like, they were the eternal dwellings of the Khmer kings, where their mortal remains would rest, and where a statue representing the monarch with the traits of a god was erected.

The concept that the main function of the reliefs was the glorification of the king formed the key element of Bosch's theory.¹⁷ For him, the apotheosis of the king was well expressed in the sequence and meaning of Angkor Wat's Large Panels of the 3rd enclosure, which would reveal an analogy between the cycle of the sun and the life of Vishnu. Vishnu's qualities as the Vedic god of solar light, energy and expansion, were embodied in the king's person and activities. All the Large Panels follow a 'gradation' sequence in which the sun moving in the sky is equated to events in the life of Vishnu, the sun-king, the king who is a solar god. Since Angkor Wat was dedicated to Vishnu, the creators of the reliefs glorified the Khmer king by identifying him with Vishnu, and at the same time attempted to make eternal his terrestrial events through their interpretation according to Vishnu's own legends.

Hinting at the religious function of the reliefs was the theory of Maurice Glaize.¹⁸ This author was of the opinion that Khmer temples were personal monuments of kings or aristocrats, pious foundations aiming at obtaining 'merits' for those who contributed to its building. Furthermore, the reliefs of the galleries of the 3rd enclosure, as any other narrative reliefs, would visually exemplify religious precepts and acquire a religious function. Glaize added that the Khmer faithful could walk in procession around the sanctuary in the ceremonial direction of the *pradakshina*, by keeping to the right, or in the opposite *prasavya* direction, reserved for funerary processions. If all the reliefs were accessible to the faithful it is not mentioned in any Khmer inscriptions nor we have proof. It is now believed that public access may have been possible only during festivities or special occasions, and under the guidance of brahmins, as in modern practice. It is likely, however, that the pilgrims were not allowed to go beyond the 3rd enclosure. In the past, in India the

devotee was not permitted to enter the shrine, nor did he need to do so. When the priest invoked a deity in the image that stood inside the *garbhagrha* ('sanctum sanctorum'), the layman stood at the threshold to witness the god's presence and experience the divine.

Jean Filliozat¹⁹ was the first to perceive that the reliefs' function could be part of broader astronomical and numerological concepts embedded in Khmer architecture. He exposed his theories in the study on the Bakheng, the temple-mountain (*see p. 11*) built in strict accordance with Indian planetary cosmology at the centre of the first town of Angkor founded by Yashovarman at the end of the IX century. In its totality, the temple (with its decorations) was conceived as a model on which the Khmer microcosm was constructed.²⁰

In 1976, a group of American scholars, R. Stencel, F. Gifford and E. Moron, published a paper revealing a cosmic symbolism created by the relationship between structures and meaning in the design of Angkor Wat. The theme was considerably expanded by Eleanor Mannikka²¹ in her controversial book of 1996. On the basis of the study of a very large number of measurements of architectural elements at Angkor Wat, she established that the temple's dimensions were encoded with the meanings of Indian cosmology and numerology. She also noticed that some alignments of the monument's structures are closely related to astronomical events. The temple's architecture is a sort of religious and astronomical text, a text that could be read by knowledgeable people walking along its main pathways. For example, as the sun progresses on its annual round, it illuminates in a specific way the great continuous series of reliefs of the 3rd gallery, revealing a most intriguing relationship between the passage of the sun and the content of the reliefs. In the first part of the year, it illuminates the main protagonists of the creation act ('Churning of the Ocean of Milk'). During the autumn equinox, on the side of the setting sun, the highlighted reliefs depict the terrible battle of Kurukshetra. During the dry season, the north gallery loses the sun, while the reliefs on the south gallery, lit up by the sun, take as their theme the kingdom of death (LP. 3).

In conclusion, the views of the previous authors contain, to a greater or lesser extent, elements of truth and provide the scholar with a better understanding of Khmer religious symbolism of the trans-

formation of an earthly site into a celestial palace, introducing the possibility of a metaphysical vision of Angkor Wat. Bosch and Mannikka's theories have the virtue of stressing the importance of astronomy and cosmology, of which the Khmer seem to have had great knowledge. On the other hand, the deco-rative and religious functions were especially relevant to the reliefs of the 3rd Enclosure's western corner pavilions. It is clear that the king would acquire further merit if his temple were ornamented with decorative and narrative reliefs, the symbolism of which enhanced and evidenced a religious belief. It was also making concrete his extraordinary power as a king. The sculptural low reliefs transformed a terrestrial building into a godly palace on a mythological mountain, and each of the narrative reliefs further contributed to the building-up of a sacred discourse permeating the entire temple of Angkor Wat.

Architectural symbolism

In ancient Cambodia, as in India, the highest religious authority, the brahmins, formulated the sacred concepts on which the temple was based, and the main architect, who was also a religious teacher, carried out its construction. The importance of the role of the architect/s is attested by an Indian legend in which a divine genealogy was provided for the chief architect and his three assistants.²² They were believed to descend from the four sons, by daughters of the gods, of the faces of Brahma. The myth itself absorbed spiritual power from all directions of space, and endowed it upon the builders involved in the enterprise of erecting a temple. The ceremonial nature of temple-building became a minor religion in its own right, complete with a set of deities, a mythology and a system of rituals unique to the science of sacred architecture (*vastu-vidyā*).

The Khmer temple was conceived according to the Indian tradition of a temple-mountain, of being the image of the mountain where the gods lived, Mount Meru. This mountain was located north of the Himalayas, surrounded by the four water extensions (seas or rivers) which separate the four continents. Mount Meru floats over the primordial ocean, symbolically represented by moats or

the *barays* surrounding the temple (or the city as in the case of Angkor Wat). Since this mountain had four peaks with a higher fifth at the centre, the central sanctuary of Angkor Wat had to have a similar configuration.²³ Moreover, since Mount Meru was the centre of the universe in Indian cosmology, Angkor Wat too had to be the centre of the cosmos. This centre of the world was 'the centre' by definition, the infinitesimal point through which the cosmic axis passes; it did not represent a profane geometrical space, but a place charged with sacred meaning. It was the idealised 'centre' of the Khmer empire and the residence of the god with whom the king had an intimate affinity.

The ritual definition of a 'centre' imposed the accurate orientation of the temple. Through the application of the formulas in place at that time (cosmological, astrological, geomantic, numerological, architectural, iconographic and so on), a space was charged with meaning and physically given form, like a mandala. The rite of deciphering or decoding, this pattern-space by walking around the temple, either by the *pradakshina* or the *prasavya* way, would have brought the visitor to discover certain truths and his/her own 'centre'. This trip, as an act of initiation, may be compared to the Tantric trip from an external mandala into an interiorised mandala. The ascent to the terraces of the mountain-temple as an ecstatic journey to the centre of the perfect Hindu universe, must be seen as ultimately symbolic of the perfection of the Hindu world over which Suryavarman II ruled with the blessing of his god, Vishnu.

Besides being at the centre of a town and the capital of the kingdom, Angkor Wat may have been the goal of a pilgrimage from other parts of the Khmer kingdom. The focus of the pilgrimage would have been its shrine in which was condensed the element of hope which justifies all pilgrimages. However, since there are no inscriptions giving light on the time of Suryavarman II, this aspect of the Khmer faith and tradition also remains unresolved.

The orientation of temples has always been an essential feature of Indian architecture. The brahmins believed that the whole earth, once floating and mobile, became stable when fixed by the cardinal points. The main points, or corners, of earth are those where heaven and the earth meet, where

the sun rises and sets, the east and west. The cardinal points complete the square and each of them has its own regent. According to Sanskrit texts on religious architecture, the northeast is the place where the principle of Shiva is positioned while the position of Surya is in the east, that of Vishnu to the west, that of Yama to the South and of Brahma at the centre. The general Indian notion that the temple's orientation must face east was adopted by the Khmer. There were only a few exceptions of orientation to the west, the better known being that of Angkor Wat because it was dedicated to Vishnu.

That the western orientation of the temple had an intense meaning for Angkor Wat's planners and builders is demonstrated by the main architectural elements being located on the western side of the temple: an imposing causeway, entrance pavilions, cruciform cloister, libraries, main shrine opening to the west, etc. Furthermore, the decorative elements (including the narrative reliefs) were completed first in the western gallery of the 3rd Enclosure and in its two corner pavilions.

The site on which the temple was constructed was a landscape space, chosen for its uniqueness and for some specific quality, such as its having had significance for the ancestors, or being the only large piece of land available within the precincts of the old town of Yashodharapura (founded in the X century), which included pre-existing ancient foundations. It may have been chosen for its proximity, on the northeast, to the old site on which the city of Kapilapura (?X century) was built. The temple's architecture transformed this natural space into a religious and political realm by means of the symbolic mediation of its shrines' pinnacles, the *gopuras*, the statues of the god and the reliefs. Those who produced this space, the brahmins and the kings, also managed it; they were the religious-political forces that occupied this space and controlled it.

Techniques of visual representation

It is evident that in order to visually narrate myths and stories, the Khmer sculptors made great use of the most common pictorial device, the ground line, or base line, on which the figures appear to stand in

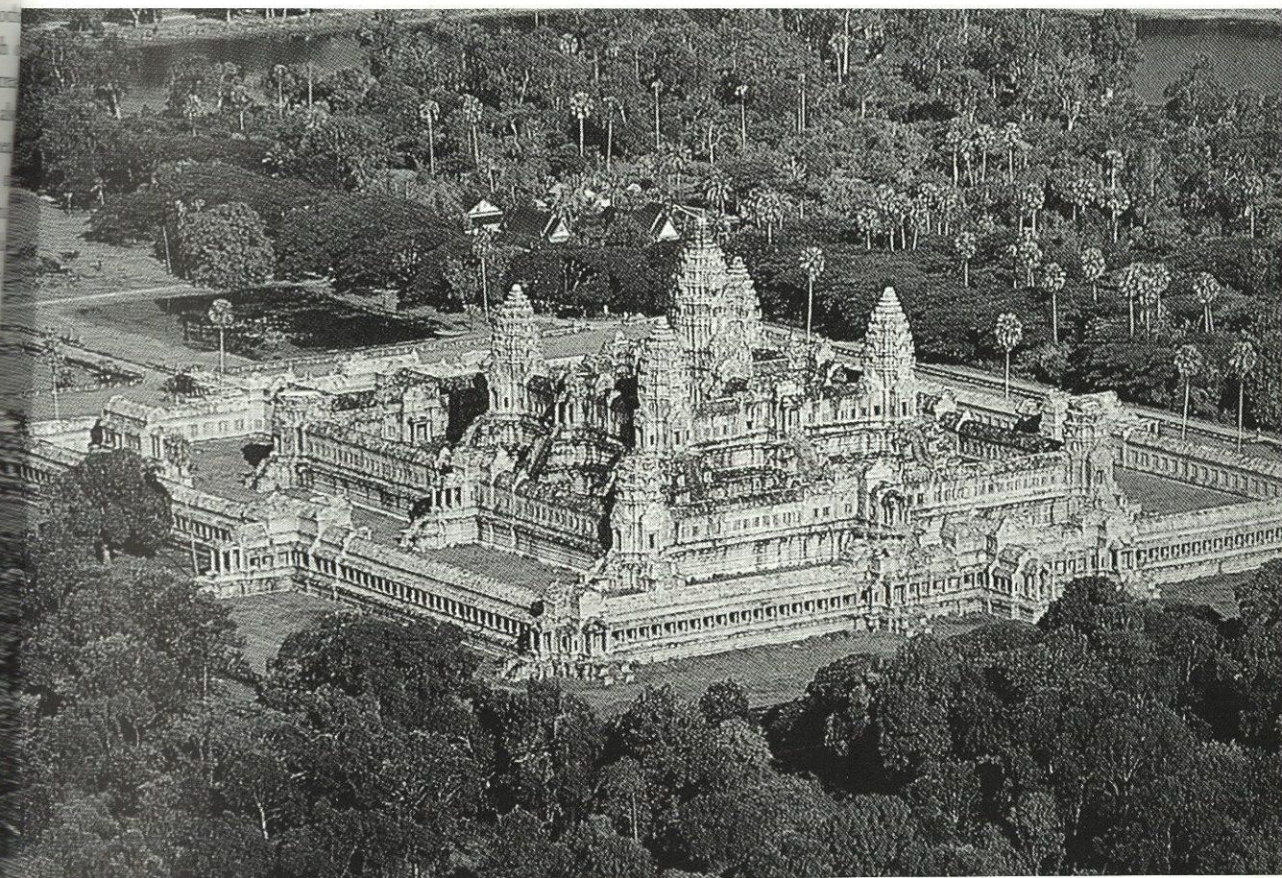


FIG. 3 Aerial view of Angkor Wat from the southeast.

the relief. This was probably in order to supplement a weak concept of picture space and the lack of a systematic perspective system. The ground line evolves into a supporting surface, a sort of narrow platform on which images rest and from which they spring. It anchors the figures and objects and links them together on the picture plane, giving them a rudimentary but definite spatial orientation. The use of ground lines leads to a horizontal arrangement of the elements of the relief, and this in turn leads to another important characteristic of Khmer reliefs, the use of registers. A register is in effect a strip existing between two parallel ground lines. It is used as a means to organise a complex narrative. One of the best examples can be seen in the panel of 'Heavens and Hells' (LP. 3).

Within the registers, the personages are organised in groups of figures each performing some characteristic action, so that we read them sequentially like a strip cartoon. But Khmer artists used registers with some freedom and we have principal figures breaking through the ground line and occupying two or more registers (cf. Yama in the 'Heavens and Hells' relief). The term pseudo-register is used when the ground lines are not sculpted as such, and the scenes are simply overlaid one on top of another without any indication of a break. In some panels of the western corner pavilions, the stories of Krishna are told in six pseudo-registers (Krishna bringing back Mount Maniparvata [N. 2], Sita's *svayamvara* [N. 10]) or even eight pseudo-registers (Sita meeting Hanuman).